Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Micah

Micah 1:1

- Micah is likely a short form of Micaiah, which means "Who is like the Lord?"
- Moresheth was a fortress city located southeast of Gath in the low hills of southwestern Judah.
- Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah (see Micah Book Introduction, "Setting"): These three kings ruled for about 65 years in total, from about 750 to 686 BC.
- God gave his message to the prophet Micah through visions (special scenes or messages God showed him).
- Samaria and Jerusalem were the capitals of northern Israel and Judah. Sometimes these city names refer to the entire countries.

Micah 1:2

- Hear!: This word translates the same Hebrew term used in the Shema, which begins with the command "Hear" in Deuteronomy 6:4. It is a call to listen carefully and respond with obedience.
- His holy temple: This refers to the Lord's dwelling place in heaven, not to the corrupt temple in Jerusalem (Micah 1:2–3).

Micah 1:2–7

This oracle speaks about Samaria before 722 BC. In that year, Samaria was destroyed and its people were taken away into exile. The Sovereign Lord was coming to judge his people.

Micah 1:2–2.13

This message of judgment focuses on key themes in Micah's prophecies. It shows God's decision to judge his people and send them into exile (Micah 1:16; 2:4–5). However, it ends with the Lord's promise to save a small group from exile (Micah 2:12–13).

Micah 1:3

Tread on the high places suggests a theophany, which is an appearance of God. This God is behind the upcoming historical events affecting Samaria (see Deuteronomy 33:29; Psalm 108:13; Amos 4:13). God rules over nations and nature. People also believed the Canaanite god Baal acted in this way. Descriptions like this highlight that the Lord, not Baal, is truly in control.

Micah 1:4

The strong and seemingly unmovable mountains will melt in the presence of the Lord (see Psalm 97:5). Nothing can stand against him.

Micah 1:5

- Transgression is the same as sins. These two words describe Israel's failure in the Old Testament.
- What is ... what it: The capital cities of God's people should have been holy places, but they became sources of corruption instead. Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom of Israel, was built by Omri, who ruled from 885 to 874 BC. It was a political, military, and economic crossroads of the ancient Near East (1 Kings 16:24). Omri was an evil king, so his city was evil (compare Micah 6:16, 1 Kings 16:25).
- Jerusalem: The prophet did not allow the people of Judah to feel superior about the northern kingdom's coming destruction. Judah's beautiful temple was no different from a Canaanite center of idol worship (high place).

Micah 1:6–7

- a heap of rubble: The Lord warned that he would completely destroy his treasured cities. Assyria almost completely destroyed Samaria in a brutal three-year siege from 724 to 722 BC.
- Samaria, like many ancient cities, was built on a hill. When the city was destroyed, soldiers pushed the stones of its walls down into the valley below. Ancient armies often tore down city walls stone by stone, all the way to the foundation.
- Samaria and Jerusalem were filled with carved images and sacred treasures placed by worshipers or taken as war loot.
- Prostitution symbolizes Israel's ongoing spiritual and physical unfaithfulness. Israelite prophets often used this metaphor to show Israel's abandonment of the Lord, her true husband, to seek blessings from pagan gods. The worship of those gods often involved sexual activity.
- Again refers to the exile of Samaria into Assyria and its various provinces and conquered vassal states, which happened in 722 BC. The same fate was predicted for Jerusalem (Micah 3:12; Jeremiah 26:18).

Micah 1:8–16

- In response to the Lord's predicted judgment, Micah walked barefoot and naked to show mourning (see Isaiah 20:2; Lamentations 2:10; Ezekiel 24:17). This act vividly showed what would happen to Samaria

(Israel) and Jerusalem (Judah). They would lose their wealth, power, and population.
- A jackal and an owl make sad sounds and live in deserted wilderness areas (see Isaiah 34:13; Jeremiah 50:39).

Micah 1:9

Judah ... Jerusalem: The corruption spread throughout the entire nation, from north to south.

Micah 1:10–15

The cities listed were in the lowlands of southwestern Judah's coastal areas. This sequence might show the Assyrian army's march down the coastal plain and then into Judah's heartland in 703 to 701 BC.

Micah 1:11

Exile was the worst and most devastating punishment (Deuteronomy 4:29; 28:37, 48; Jeremiah 25:7–11).

Micah 1:12

even to ... Jerusalem: God's judgment reaches everywhere corruption has spread (compare Micah 1:9).

Micah 1:13

Lachish was the second most important city in Judah, after Jerusalem. It served as Judah's main defense center against enemies. Today, a large tell (or mound) over 46 meters (150 feet) high still exists. Lachish fell in 701 BC after being besieged, terrified, starved, and destroyed by Sennacherib's war machines. Sennacherib celebrated the fall of Lachish as one of his greatest victories and featured the event in large carvings on his palace walls.

Micah 1:14

Farewell gifts marked the end for the people of Moresheth-gath, as the Assyrians took control of the city.

Micah 1:15

- The glory: The leaders of Israel were supposed to be the nation's "glory" by showing moral excellence and wise, caring leadership. Instead, God's shepherds corrupted their nation.
- Assyria destroyed Adullam in 701 BC.

Micah 1:16

- The people of Judah, including those from Jerusalem, were exiled to faraway lands in Babylonia in 605, 597, and 586 BC. Babylon was about 1,700 kilometers (1,000 miles) from Jerusalem.
- Shave yourselves: This was an act of mourning and despair (see also Jeremiah 41:5). It could also mean purification (Leviticus 14:7–10; Numbers 6:10–11).

Micah 2:1–2

- Power had corrupted the wealthy, who should have been ready to help their fellow Israelites (compare Genesis 4:9; Joshua 1:14).
- Thinking up evil plans because you have the power to do so shows a corrupt heart, mind, and character (Genesis 6:5).
- They covet: They took others' property, which was like stealing and broke God's law against coveting (Exodus 20:17). A family's inheritance was a sacred gift from the Lord, meant to be a permanent possession (Leviticus 25:8–55; compare 1 Kings 21; Isaiah 5:8). God sought righteousness among his people, but instead, he found oppression (1 Kings 10:9; Isaiah 5:7; 2 Peter 2:13).

Micah 2:3–5

The Lord, acting as a judge, announces the sentence. He will repay his people's wicked hearts and actions with disaster. The prophet uses wordplay here. The Hebrew word for "evil" has many meanings. It can mean moral evil, as in the first case, or calamity or disaster, as in the second. The Lord will bring disaster on them because of their wickedness.

Micah 2:4

The leaders would lose their wealth when their enemies took their property. The land they had taken unfairly from other Israelites would be taken away from them in return (Micah 2:5).

Micah 2:6

- There was a weak attempt to silence a true prophet.
- they preach: They believed that exile and other disasters could not happen to them, but they were mistaken.

Micah 2:7–10

Mistreating their fellow Israelites was like attacking the Lord and his prophet. The people were at fault, not Micah's inspired and righteous message.

Micah 2:11

These wicked individuals enjoyed listening to lies from their favorite prophets who promised good times (compare Jeremiah 28:8–9). False prophets assured Israel and Judah that they could avoid judgment. When judgment arrived, they offered no comfort.

Micah 2:12–13

God demonstrated his love and care for his rebellious people by promising them hope, even while mentioning exile and despair. Although Israel would be scattered, they would return (compare Deuteronomy 4:26–29; 30:1–6).

Micah 2:13

The Lord led Israel out of exile, hinting at the greater freedom from slavery that the Messiah, Jesus Christ, would later provide.

Micah 3:1

The leaders, expected to understand true judgment and justice (Micah 6:8; Deuteronomy 10:12–13), were morally responsible for Israel's guilt.

Micah 3:1–4

Micah strongly criticized the leaders of Israel because they were responsible for the people's well-being. The horrors described here show the fears of people under attack (compare Deuteronomy 28:53; 2 Kings 6:29).

Micah 3:1–5.15

This message accuses the evil leaders who harmed God's people. It contrasts them with a vision of God's kingdom and a righteous king's rule. After facing judgment and exile, a purified Israel would return and receive God's blessings.

Micah 3:2–3

The leaders acted like wild animals. They harmed their own people and treated them without mercy.

Micah 3:4

Then: Even after oppressing the Lord's people, the leaders selfishly asked the Lord for help.

Micah 3:5

The false prophets were part of Israel's spiritual leadership, so Micah included them in his accusations. Prophets were meant to guide Israel in the right way, not to lead the people away from God (see Deuteronomy 13, 18). Instead, these prophets used their gifts for their own benefit.

Micah 3:6–7

Micah announced God's judgment on the false prophets. Without God's special messages, these seers and fortune-tellers were like the pagan court prophets of nations like Babylon, Mari, and especially Assyria. Those prophets were expected to say what the rulers wanted to hear, but they did not receive true messages from the Lord 1 Samuel 28:6; Amos 8:11–12).

Micah 3:8

There was a big difference between the true prophet and the false prophets (Micah 3:5–7). Truth, justice, and power come from God's Spirit. This Spirit gave Micah the moral and ethical strength to speak his true message about the sin and rebellion of his people.

Micah 3:9–12

The leaders of Israel built Jerusalem on murder and corruption. Because of this, the city would become a wilderness and ruins (Micah 3:12).

Micah 3:11

Is not the LORD among us?: This expression shows the Lord's approval (see Exodus 3:12, 14; 25:8; Micah 2:5; Zechariah 2:11) and his presence among his people. The false prophets wrongly claimed God's presence.

Micah 3:12

- Mount Zion, where the Lord once lived, would become a dense forest and an uninhabitable wilderness. Complete destruction awaited the fallen Jerusalem. Jeremiah later quoted this passage (Jeremiah 26:18)
- Just as a field needs clearing for cultivation, Jerusalem had to be reduced to ruins as a form of judgment.

Micah 4:1–2

- In the last days: God promised to act in history to establish his kingdom.
- The mountain of the house of the LORD refers to Mount Zion in Jerusalem, where Solomon's temple was built (see 2 Samuel 24:18–25). It reminds us of Mount Sinai, the mountain of God (Exodus 3:1; Numbers 10:33), where God appeared. The mountain of the Lord is important as the place where God reveals his identity and offers fellowship.
- teach us His ways ... His paths: The wisdom of God's laws and the knowledge of his ways will give life to the nations (Deuteronomy 4:6; 32:47).

Micah 4:1–5

Micah's prophecy shifts from deep despair to a burst of hope as he describes the future rise of Mount Zion in Jerusalem. God's plan to bless all nations (Genesis 12:3) through Abraham's descendants will come true

when people from all nations gather at the Lord's house to worship. There:

1. they will learn to follow God's laws and teachings;
2. these laws and teachings will spread among the nations as they leave God's house;
3. peace and well-being will grow as nations focus on peaceful activities and stop waging war; and
4. people will live without fear, enjoying security, prosperity, and blessings (Micah 4:4).

The idols of the nations fail them, but Israel's faithful God achieves all this. The prosperity he brings lasts forever (Micah 4:5).

Micah 4:3

- The shalom ("well-being, peace") of the Lord will cover the earth, and tools of destruction will be used for peaceful activities. Ancient history, from its earliest records, tells of war and one group dominating others. Warfare and violence peaked in the Assyrian and Babylonian kingdoms.
- swords into plowshares: Weapons will become tools for farming. Some scholars think this phrase means turning "swords into metal shards," making them useless.

Micah 4:4

- Everyone will live without enemies, like in Solomon's time (1 Kings 4:25; compare Isaiah 36:16; Zechariah 3:10).
- The prophets often called God the LORD of Hosts. This military title shows his control over the universe and his unlimited power. The warrior kings of the ancient Near East could not compete with the Lord.

Micah 4:6–7

In the ancient Near East, the survivors of destroyed cities were usually scattered or absorbed into other peoples. But when God rescued Israel's remnant, those survivors became the beginning of the Lord's renewed people (Deuteronomy 4:26–31; 30:1–5; 2 Kings 19:31; Isaiah 10:21; Jeremiah 29:10–14; see Ezra 9:8; Nehemiah 1:2).

Micah 4:8

- And you, O watchtower of the flock: Jerusalem was a fortified royal capital city with a watchtower for the defense and security of its people.
- the former dominion will be restored: compare Amos 9:11–15; see 2 Samuel 7:11–16.

Micah 4:9

Israel's king and wise people were meant to lead and live by the Lord's instructions and covenant (Deuteronomy 17:18–20). Now, however, the people would lack godly leadership (compare Judges 17:6; 18:1; 21:25).

Micah 4:10

- Babylon was about 1,700 kilometers (1,000 miles) from Jerusalem. People could not reach it by crossing the barren eastern desert.
- The Lord's rescue of his people from certain death in Babylon would be greater than when he brought them out of Egypt. They were shaped in the womb of suffering and awaited a hopeful rebirth (Isaiah 43:1–5; compare Ezekiel 37).
- For Micah, Babylon symbolized exile. In Micah's time (the late 700s and early 600s BC), there was no sign of a Babylonian empire replacing the Assyrians. But Micah spoke for God, who knows the future.

Micah 4:11–13

assembled against you: This refers first to the attack of Babylon against Jerusalem in 588–586 BC. At the same time, it also points to a future attack against a restored and ideal Jerusalem described in Micah 4:1–5 (compare Revelation 20:7–9).

Micah 4:12

- God reveals his plans to his servants (Daniel 2:19–23; Amos 3:7), but the nations do not know. They are not aware of God's great plans or his actions behind the scenes for his people. The hopes and plans of the nations around Israel were in vain. The Lord's plans for his unique people will succeed, and he will rule the nations (Genesis 12:1–3; 15:12–21; Exodus 19:4–6; Isaiah 45:23; 66:23).
- At the threshing floor, people beat and trampled grain to separate it from the chaff. Similarly, the nations will be crushed (Micah 4:13).

Micah 4:13

- The horns and hooves of bulls and horses symbolize strength, just like iron and bronze. People may have used metal shoes on animals that helped with farming. God will give strength to his people to defeat their enemies.
- their gain: Many nations gathered wealth unfairly through war, plunder, heavy taxes, forced labor, and conscription. The Lord of all the earth originally owned all this wealth (Exodus 19:5).

- you will devote: The Hebrew term (kharam, meaning "dedicate") refers to war spoils set aside as holy to the Lord (see Leviticus 27:28–29).

Micah 5:1

The Assyrians defeated Israel's leader (compare Micah 6:9). Hitting someone with a rod showed disrespect (compare 1 Kings 22:24).

Micah 5:1–15

This section urges Israel to prepare for the fierce attack by Assyria, Israel's enemy (Micah 5:5b–6). This terrifying siege will not destroy Israel, because God will provide a leader (Micah 5:2–5a) to guide the people back from exile. God will preserve and purify the remaining people (Micah 5:7–14), completing their restoration as God's victorious people.

Micah 5:2

Ephrathah was the ancient name of Bethlehem (Genesis 35:16; Ruth 4:11), where David was born. In the future, a ruler greater than David would come from there (Matthew 2:5–6; John 7:42). This future king's influence would span from the distant past (Hebrew qedem; compare Deuteronomy 33:27; Proverbs 8:22–23; Isaiah 37:26) to a time yet to come, suggesting a divine-human being.

Micah 5:4–5

After the exile in Babylon, Prince Zerubbabel, a descendant of David, was among the returning exiles and became the focus of Israel's hopes (see Haggai 2:20–23). However, Israel needed a greater ruler than Zerubbabel. The leader from Bethlehem would bring peace; Isaiah called him the Prince of Peace (Isaiah 9:6). Only Jesus fits this description.

Micah 5:5

- The Assyrians destroyed northern Israel in 722 BC. In 701 BC, Sennacherib trapped King Hezekiah of Jerusalem "like a bird in a cage" (Sennacherib's own words) and devastated over 46 cities in Judah. The expected deliverer-king did not appear during that time. The Assyrians symbolize all of Israel's enemies.
- seven shepherds ... eight leaders: This phrase means there will be plenty of leaders to guide Israel as needed.

Micah 5:6

the land of Nimrod: Nimrod was a powerful early ruler. He helped establish the first cities of what later became the Assyrian and Babylonian civilizations (Genesis 10:8–11).

Micah 5:7

- The remnant refers to those whom God's grace saved to form the foundation of his new people (Ezra 9:8–15; Nehemiah 1:2).
- Dew and rain are gifts from the Lord. No human being can stop him from sending them.

Micah 5:7–15

God did not aim to create just another nation (Exodus 19:4–6; Numbers 23:9; Jeremiah 7:23). He wanted his own people to follow his ways and be holy like him (Leviticus 11:45). In that time (Micah 5:10), God will lead a redeemed and purified people, free from violence and the damage of war.

Micah 5:8–9

- God's people will have a special role among the world's nations (Genesis 12:3; Exodus 19:4–6). They will lead and not follow (Deuteronomy 28:13), and be as strong as a lion (compare Esther 6:13) as God grants them power over the nations.
- The Lord will judge their enemies (see Micah 5:15) if they keep rebelling against him. However, the Lord's ultimate wish is to bless the nations, not to curse or destroy them (Genesis 12:3; Jonah 4:11; John 3:16).

Micah 5:10–14

The Lord's actions, both for and against his people, cleanse them. He removed practices and objects that Israel had taken from the pagan cultures of Mesopotamia and Canaan.

Micah 5:13–14

sacred pillars ... Asherah poles: Stones and trees were used for worship. They could symbolize pagan gods. The Asherah poles were green poles or trees representing the goddess Asherah and her fertility powers. The stones and trees might have had sexual meanings—one male, the other female. People viewed Asherah as the mother of gods and the partner of El or Baal.

Micah 6:1–2

mountains ... hills: All creation is called as a witness (see Joshua 24:27). In other ancient Near Eastern treaties, they called the gods of the countries as witnesses.

Micah 6:1–16

The Lord presented, argued, and decided a case against his rebellious people, Israel. This section is written as a formal legal court case. Other prophets use the same pattern (compare Isaiah 1:2–4; Jeremiah 2:4–9; Hosea 4).

Using the image of a courtroom, the Lord challenged his people to state their case against him. At the same time, he stated his case against them (Micah 6:1–5). The people had not obeyed what the Lord required of them (Micah 6:6–8), so they were found guilty (6:9–12).

After the guilty verdict, the passage describes Israel's punishment. This final section announces the sentence that follows the judgment (Micah 6:13–16).

Micah 6:3

wearied you!: The Lord asks if he has done anything to make Israel turn away from him. However, their disrespect for God comes from their own lack of gratitude (Micah 6:4–5).

Micah 6:4–5

- The Lord led Israel out of Egypt, protected them, and blessed them on their journey to the promised land. God urged Israel to always remember what he had done for them from Sinai onward (Exodus 3:15; Deuteronomy 5:15; Psalms 77:11; 111:4; see also Psalms 78, 136).
- Balak ... Balaam: (see Numbers 22–24).
- Shittim, east of the Jordan River, was Israel's base camp before entering the promised land (see Numbers 25:1; Joshua 2:1; 3:1). The journey from there to Gilgal (west of the Jordan River) shows God's faithful covenant. God's saving acts brought the Israelites into the promised land.

Micah 6:6–7

Israel's situation seemed hopeless, so they asked the Lord how to please him. They offered increasingly significant items, from calves to rams, olive oil, and even firstborn children. None of these offerings was enough or acceptable to God, who judges the heart (1 Samuel 15:22; 16:7; Jeremiah 17:9).

Micah 6:8

- Good means what is right in God's eyes. God is the source of all goodness (Genesis 1; Exodus 33:19; 34:6–7; Deuteronomy 12:28).
- what is good (Hebrew mishpat, often translated as "justice"): This means treating others fairly and without manipulation or oppression.
- mercy (Hebrew khesed): This is a deep, undeserved loyalty that defines God's holy character (see Psalm 136). Those who know God should act this way toward others (see Genesis 21:22–24; Joshua 2:12–14; Matthew 5:43–48).
- walk humbly: God's people must live with humility. They must not act with pride or claim special privilege. Instead, they should live in reverent fear of God (deep respect and awe). Mishpat ("justice") and khesed ("mercy") cannot exist together with human pride. God wants an ongoing, close relationship with his people. This relationship is described as a "walk" (a way of living life each day). This walk changes how people treat one another (compare Deuteronomy 28:9; Joshua 22:5).

Micah 6:9

- Wise people respect the Lord. God's voice invites everyone in Jerusalem to learn wisdom (compare Proverbs 1:7, 20, 28).
- Heed the rod ... who ordained it: Assyria would carry out the Lord's plan to destroy Samaria, while Babylon would be the instrument of destruction for Jerusalem (Micah 4:10).

Micah 6:9–16

People in Jerusalem were invited to learn from Samaria: If you oppress others to gain wealth (Micah 6:10–12), you will never have enough, no matter how much you acquire (6:13–15). Eventually, you will lose even that (Micah 6:16). Such people deserve scorn, not honor and praise (Micah 6:16).

Micah 6:10–12

The Lord brought clear charges against his people. Israel had become a community marked by lies and dishonesty. Because of this, they faced rejection and destruction.

The people gained wealth through dishonest means. They used unfair business practices and relied on threats and violence. These actions were not fitting for people who claimed to belong to God (see 2 Kings 6:25; Hosea 12:7–8; Amos 8:5–6).

They were unable to change because lying had become their normal way of life (compare Proverbs 6:16–19). As a result, Israel was corrupt in every part of its life.

Micah 6:13–16

I am striking you severely: This phrase introduces the curses God promised to bring upon the disobedient

and rebellious people of Israel (see Deuteronomy 28:15–68).

Micah 6:16

These kings started perhaps the most rebellious dynasty in northern Israel that lasted from 885 to 841 BC (1 Kings 16:23—2 Kings 10:17). Elijah predicted their destruction (2 Kings 10:17). No northern kings of Israel followed the laws of Moses (see Micah 1:5–6).

Omri and his son Ahab were the worst of the evil kings (for example, 1 Kings 18:4; 21:1–26). Omri's family line of kings was destroyed by Jehu, whom the Lord appointed to judge the royal house of Israel, in 841 BC (2 Kings 9:14–10:17). In the same way, the people of Israel who followed this evil example would also be destroyed by the Lord.

Micah 7:1

gathering summer fruit at the gleaning of the vineyard: After the second crop of figs and fruit in August to September (toward the end of summer), no more fruit was produced for several months (see Isaiah 16:9; Jeremiah 48:32). No one could satisfy Micah's hunger for righteousness (Micah 7:2–6).

Micah 7:1–20

Hopeless deception and corruption filled God's people (Micah 7:1–6). Because of this, Micah mourned their condition and turned to the Lord for help (Micah 7:7–10).

Even so, God's mercy would triumph. Israel would be restored by the Lord (Micah 7:11–13). God's mercy, compassion, and unfailing love would prevail in the end (Micah 7:14–20).

Micah 7:2

- This complaint often appears in the prophets (see Isaiah 59:16; Jeremiah 5:1; Ezekiel 22:30).
- In the ancient Near East, people caught fish and hunted by setting traps and using nets (compare Psalm 10:9; Proverbs 1:17; Isaiah 51:20).
- one another: All fellow Israelites were regarded as brothers.

Micah 7:2–6

The people of Israel were without law, justice, or righteousness. Everyone took advantage of others for personal gain. This created a society in which all forms of oppression were normal.

Micah 7:3

- skilled at evil: That is, they had learned how to do evil very well.
- the prince and the judge demand a bribe: The law forbade rulers and judges from accepting bribes or turning justice in the wrong direction (Exodus 18:19–22; Deuteronomy 16:18–20). Because of this, Israel's legal system no longer worked in a fair way.

Micah 7:4

The day for your watchmen has come: The people of Israel will soon be conquered by the Assyrians. The people of Judah will soon face destruction by the Babylonians. All the people of the earth will soon face God in judgment.

Micah 7:5–6

Do not rely on a friend: Bitterness, corruption, and betrayal had harmed the community of the Lord's people (compare Matthew 10:34–36; Luke 12:52–53).

Micah 7:7–10

During a difficult time, Micah prays with a psalm expressing hope and trust in the Lord (compare Habakkuk 2:4; 3:16–18).

Micah 7:8

though I sit in darkness: The prophet trusts God to be his light (see Psalm 27:1). He knows his enemies will not defeat him (compare Psalm 23:4–5). God's spirit gives him the strength and confidence to carry out his prophetic duties (Micah 3:8).

Micah 7:9

- I have sinned: The prophet and other religious people admit their mistakes and responsibility, yet trust in the Lord for redemption.
- The Lord's righteousness saves and rescues his people.

Micah 7:10

Where is the LORD your God?: This question was spoken as a taunt. It mocked God and those who trusted in him.

God had promised that he would always be with his people and their leaders (Genesis 46:3–4; Exodus 3:12). These taunts dishonored God's name. Because of this, God would act to defend his honor and show his faithfulness (compare Ezekiel 20:9; 36:19–26).

Micah 7:11–12

That day includes:

1. 538 BC, when Israel began to return from exile in Babylon (see Ezra 1–2); and
2. the final restoration of God's people (see Amos 9:11–15).

As the nations come to a renewed Israel, God will fulfill his purposes through Abraham (see Genesis 12:3).

Micah 7:13

- Before their restoration, Israel must face discipline (Deuteronomy 4:29; 28:37, 48, 63; 30:1–6).
- desolate: The people's stubborn wickedness led to God's judgments.

Micah 7:14

- A shepherd in the ancient Near East used a staff to protect sheep from wild animals. Similarly, the prophet prayed for God to protect his people from hostile non-Jewish nations (compare Exodus 4:1–5).
- Your inheritance: compare Exodus 19:5; Deuteronomy 7:6; 14:2; 26:18; Malachi 3:17; 1 Peter 2:9.
- Bashan and Gilead, located east of the Jordan River, were among the Lord's earliest gifts to the Israelite tribes of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh (Joshua 13:15–31). Assyria took over these areas and exiled these tribes in the 700s BC. Israel would regain and expand its ownership.

Micah 7:14–20

The Lord promised to fully renew Israel, his special possession (see Exodus 19:5; Malachi 3:17). Judgment would not destroy hope but cleanse it so true hope could thrive. God alone would restore the remnant of his special people and remove their guilt through his love, compassion, and faithfulness (see Exodus 32:12–14).

Micah 7:15

Israel was enslaved to sin and to other nations. This situation required powerful acts from God, like the miracles he used to bring Israel out of Egypt.

Micah 7:16

God promised that all nations would receive blessings through Abraham's descendants (Genesis 12:3). This promise would come true with the restoration of God's chosen people.

Micah 7:17

Like snakes, the nations had attacked Israel's heel (compare Genesis 3:14–15). The prophets often described foreign nations as deceitful, poisonous serpents (Isaiah 14:29; Jeremiah 8:17; Ezekiel 29:1–3). Now these nations would face humiliation (compare Psalm 72:9). Crawling and "licking dust" were metaphors for defeat and humiliation.

Micah 7:18–20

- These verses summarize Old Testament theology well. God is unique. Nothing and no one compares to God. Because of God's unfailing love (Hebrew khesed), he does not destroy his people when he judges them. Instead, he restores them (see Exodus 36:6–7). His faithfulness means he can be trusted to do good, no matter the cost to himself (see Psalm 89:1–2).
- Who is a God like You: This question likely refers to Micah's name, which means "Who is like the Lord?" God's character is unmatched among the gods of other nations. His actions and words reflect his character (Exodus 34:6–7). God pardons, shows compassion, triumphs over his people's sins, and seals those sins away.

The Lord's unfailing love led him to choose Israel from the start (Deuteronomy 7:8), consistent with his covenant faithfulness to Israel's ancestors (Deuteronomy 7:20; 9:1–10:22). Through his unfailing love, God continues to offer hope to those who trust in him.